

Avi Moorthy

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Employment **Analysis Group**
Associate, 2026-present

Education **Harvard University**
Ph.D. Public Policy, 2026
Committee: Will Dobbie (chair), Desmond Ang, Claudia Goldin
Carleton College
B.A. Economics, *magna cum laude*, 2018

Working Papers ***The Defender on the Move: Black Newspapers and the Great Migration***
Job Market Paper

After 50 years of limited migration following emancipation, 1.5 million Black southerners made the journey north during the First Great Migration from 1915 to 1940. I examine whether information on northern life and jobs sparked Black migration using quasi-random variation in exposure to the Chicago Defender, the most prominent northern Black newspaper. Classifying the coverage of thousands of southern newspapers, I show that information about the North was limited prior to the Chicago Defender's entry in the mid-1910s. To reach southern readers, the Chicago Defender partnered with Black railway porters working for the Illinois Central railroad. In cities along the railroad, I find that individuals who lived near a porter were 33% more likely to migrate north than similar individuals who did not. These individuals pulled relatives to migrate, consistent with information diffusion across social networks, and moved to cities that received more coverage in articles, ads, and job postings. Counties with access to the Chicago Defender were 1.5 times more likely to form an NAACP branch and experienced 1.4 times fewer lynchings.

Paywalls
with Desmond Ang, Stephen Pettigrew, and Ben Schneer

Through the 2010s, the news media landscape shifted from an ad-supported to a subscription-based model. What are the effects of the transition? We examine the impact of local newspaper paywalls on news consumption, online browsing behavior, and the implications for voting, economic knowledge, and community engagement. We assemble the most comprehensive database to date tracking the implementation of paywalls for the universe of U.S. daily newspapers. We show that local newspapers skew right-leaning compared to other online news sources and attract readers who are older, whiter, and higher income. We find a sharp drop in time spent reading local newspapers after paywalls are implemented and a compositional shift toward wealthier readers. Individuals shift news consumption toward national news websites with more left-leaning ideological slants, soft news, and entertainment media. These substitution patterns cascade into a host of downstream outcomes, including a leftward shift in local residents' voting behavior and decreased knowledge of local economic conditions and social activity.

State of Mind and Human Capital Formation: Evidence from Indian Schools

with Kevin Carney

Around 83% of U.S. K-12 schools have implemented a social-emotional learning (SEL) curriculum, yet we have little evidence on their efficacy. We study the effects of India's "Happiness Curriculum," the world's largest SEL curriculum, reaching millions of students in grades 1–8. The Happiness Curriculum replaces the first 30 minutes of each school day with guided mindfulness meditation followed by stories and activities designed to help students understand their thoughts, emotions, and relationships. We conduct a randomized control trial in partnership with the state of Tripura following over 4,000 students for 2 years. We randomly assign grades to receive either the Happiness Curriculum, daily mindfulness practice, or teaching-as-usual. Students' math scores in SEL and mindfulness grades increase by 0.12 SD after 6 months and 0.29 SD after 2 years, equivalent to an additional year of learning. Math gains are driven by daily mindfulness practice and likely operate through improved reasoning and problem-solving. We observe little effect on measures of anxiety or depression. Our results reveal that programs targeting state of mind can be cost-effective ways to improve academic achievement.

Papers in Progress

Blowin' in the Wind: The Impact of Climate Disasters on College Majors and Innovation
with Chloe Tanaka

Other Publications & Working Papers

The Effect of Education on Later Life Health Revisited
FEDS Working Paper 2022-007, with Ted Figinski and Alicia Lloro

How Does Social Distancing Affect the Spread of Covid-19 in the United States?
Chicago Fed Letter, No 442, 2020, with Bhaskhar Mazumder

Teaching

Race and the State: The Role of Public Policy in U.S. Racial Inequality, Harvard Kennedy School Course Assistant (MPP level), Desmond Ang, 2023

Intermediate Price Theory, Carleton College
Teaching Assistant (undergraduate level), Jenny Bourne, 2017-2018

Introduction to Macroeconomics, Carleton College
Teaching Assistant (undergraduate level), Nathan Grawe, 2016

Introduction to Microeconomics, Carleton College
Teaching Assistant (undergraduate level), Nathan Grawe and Prathi Seneviratne, 2015-2016

Pre-Doctoral Experience

Research Assistant, Federal Reserve Bank of Chicago, 2018-2020
Summer Intern, U.S. Department of Treasury Office of Economic Policy, 2017
Summer Analyst, Cornerstone Research, 2016

Fellowships & Awards

William Julius Wilson Research Award, Harvard Kennedy School, 2026
Stone Ph.D. Scholar in Inequality and Wealth Concentration, Harvard Kennedy School, 2022
Top Undergraduate Senior Thesis, Minnesota Economics Association, 2018
Ada M. Harrison Prize in Economics, Carleton College, 2018

Phi Beta Kappa, Carleton College, 2018
Dean's List, Carleton College, 2016-2017

Grants

The Weiss Fund, with Kevin Carney, 2025 (\$14,343)
Development Innovation Ventures, with Kevin Carney, 2024 (\$910,000)
Harvard Stone Research Grant, 2024 (\$1,670)
Fund for Innovation in Development, with Kevin Carney, 2023 (\$680,530)
J-PAL Learning for All Initiative, with Kevin Carney, 2023 (\$43,276)
The Weiss Fund, with Kevin Carney, 2023 (\$50,000)
Harvard Stone Research Grant, 2023 (\$2,500)
Harvard Mind Brain and Behaviour Initiative, 2022 (\$10,000)
J-PAL Post-Primary Education Initiative, 2021 (\$31,724)

Affiliations

Ph.D. Affiliate, Harvard Centre for International Development / EPoD, 2022-2026
Doctoral Fellow, Harvard Environmental Economics Program, 2020-2026

**Invited
Seminars &
Conferences**

2026: HKS Program on Democracy and the Informed Public; HKS Stone Scholar Symposium
2025: HKS Shorenstein Centre Research Exchange; SEA 95th Annual Meeting (Clio/EHA); LSE Graduate Economic History Seminar; HKS Economics and Social Policy Seminar; Harvard Economic History Seminar, Harvard History, Culture, and Society Workshop; Harvard Labour/Public Graduate Student Workshop
2023: Harvard Environmental Economics Graduate Student Workshop; HKS CID Ph.D. Retreat

Service

Referee, *American Journal of Health Economics* and *Journal of Policy Analysis and Management*
Ph.D. Representative, Harvard Rights and Responsibilities Committee, 2022-2026
Chair, Kennedy Ph.D. Student Association Mentorship & Wellness Committees, 2020-2023
Safety Liaison, Federal Reserve Bank of Chicago, 2018-2020
Student Department Advisor, Carleton College Department of Economics, 2017-2018

Other

Languages: English (native), French (intermediate)
Software: Stata, Python, ArcGIS, R, LaTeX, RATS
Citizenship: Dual citizen of Canada and U.S.